The Door Was Waiting

The first time Adaeze tried the door it took her four minutes. The second time, six. By the third visit the door had begun to do something — a hesitation at the threshold the length of a breath, then the small mechanical reconsideration she felt in her wrists before she heard it. She stood in the corridor on the fourth floor of the converted school building and understood, before she let herself understand it, that she was getting worse.

Iyla was paying her by the hour. The hours had a thrum now. They ran against a meter Adaeze could feel under her sternum whenever Iyla messaged.

Any luck?

Working on it.

Take your time.

The taking was not the problem. The time was. Each time she set her shoulder against the door and walked the way she had taught herself to walk — slow, slightly off the heel, weight committed late, the way she had got into nine doors of this make in two years — the door learned something about her. She felt the learning. It was like being looked at by a face that had begun to remember her face, and was deciding what to do with the memory.

She had taken the job because she needed it. The agency had gone monthly with everyone under thirty and the freelance work had thinned since the building chains began their exclusivity offers — the ones where you were paid a retainer to be on no other building's call list. She had not signed any of them. She could see what they were buying. She had not signed, and she had also not been eating breakfast, and these two facts were sitting in her body like a debt and the interest on it.

Iyla had said, on the phone: *My mother told me, in the last year, that she had left something in the door. I assumed it was a metaphor. I'm beginning to think it wasn't.*

Adaeze had said: *Doors don't keep things.*

Iyla had said: *This door does.*

Sunita had been waiting. She did not know she had been waiting until she got the email from the locksmith — *I think you might be the only person in the building who can help me with something* — and her hand went to her mouth before she had read past the second line, and she sat with her hand at her mouth for almost a minute, which was unusual for her. She was not, generally, a woman whose hands moved without permission.

The account had been open for eight months. She had marked it for review three times and not actioned any of the reviews. The line read *ALLEYNE, M. — flat 4.2 — model retained pending overwrite, see notes.* She had written the note. *Defer: cost in eng-hrs > recovery, see Q4 reg. analysis. Revisit Q1.* Q1 had passed. She had not revisited.

She had told herself, in the voice she used to end conversations, that it was an accounting decision. The cost-per-hour of an engineer to retrain the doors of the fourth floor against a model no one was using — including the regression-cost of nearby tenants whose recognition would briefly degrade during the retrain — was higher than the cost of leaving Marguerite Alleyne in the system. The flat had been let to a young couple who used the keypad anyway, because their lease was new and they had not yet generated stable templates. The door had not noticed them. The door was, in a thin computational sense, still expecting Marguerite.

Sunita had not noticed, until the email arrived, that this had begun to feel like company.

She wrote back: *I can meet you in the lobby café tomorrow morning before nine.* Then, because the message looked too short, she added: *Earl Grey.* Then she deleted *Earl Grey* because she did not know why she had written it. She did know. Marguerite Alleyne had ordered Earl Grey every morning in the lobby café for eight years before her death, and Sunita had watched her order it from the accounts office window across the courtyard, and had constructed, over those eight years, a small unannounced reading of the woman: that she would not speak before her tea was made; that she sat with her shoulders down; that on Fridays she carried a different book than on the other days. Sunita had never spoken to her. She had reviewed her account, line by line, every quarter. The reading had been entirely one-sided, which was the kind of reading Sunita preferred.

She sent the email without *Earl Grey.* Then she sat at her desk and did not move for a long time.

Iyla, in Manchester, was not sleeping well. She had not slept well since the funeral. She was a paediatric registrar; she could function on five hours and had been functioning on four. Her partner had stopped asking. The mother had been the kind of mother whose death was supposed to release things — that was the unspoken arithmetic — and instead Iyla had found that her mother's absence was more administrative than her presence had been. There were forms. There were boxes. There was the flat to be sold, which she had not put on the market, because every time she went into it the air had no smell and she sat on the kitchen chair and could not produce a thought.

The thing her mother had said about the door had come at the end of a phone call about something else. Iyla had not been listening properly. She had been driving. *I've left something in the door,* her mother had said, and made the small dry

laugh she made when she meant it and did not want to be asked. *It will be there when I'm gone, and that is more than I can say for most of what I've written.* Then she had moved on. Iyla had moved on with her.

Now she could not move on.

She had hired Adaeze because Adaeze's name had come up in a forum she had found at three in the morning, where the word *unenrollable* was used and where someone had described the locksmith as *the last one who is still picking, not negotiating*. Iyla did not know what *negotiating* meant in this context. She knew she did not want to negotiate. She wanted the door open.

What she had not told Adaeze, because she did not yet know how to say it, was that she was not entirely sure what she wanted to find. She had said *something my mother told me she had left there*, which was true. She had not said *I want a door that knows my mother to know me*, which was the actual sentence. She did not know it was the sentence until she was standing at the threshold of the lobby café watching a small woman in a pale grey kurta wait for her with a cup of black tea, and the woman looked up and Iyla had a feeling she had not had in eight months — the feeling of being approached by someone who already had a column of observations on her, and who was not going to share the column, and who was, for that reason alone, the first person she had wanted to sit down with since November.

The café was on the courtyard side of the lobby. The door from the courtyard was not gait-recognising; it was an old wooden door the building had kept for the look of it, with a brass handle and a key. Sunita had let herself in with a key. Adaeze, when she arrived, came through the front lobby and through the inner doors, which had read her gait fractionally and let her through. The chime sounded. She heard it because she always heard it. She also heard that the chime was flatter than

yesterday's by — she did not put a number on it; she had stopped putting numbers on it after the second year — by enough to mean the door had lost a step of confidence in her overnight.

Sunita stood up to shake her hand. The hand was small and dry and the grip was complete. Adaeze, who was good at hands, recognised that this woman had decided, before the meeting, to give a handshake she would not have given by reflex. The decision was the warmth; the handshake itself was correct.

Iyla arrived four minutes later and ordered nothing. They sat in a triangle.

"I want to be careful," Sunita said, "about what I say to you. I am not authorised to say any of it. You should know that before I begin."

"I'm not recording," Iyla said.

"That isn't the issue."

Adaeze said: "What's the issue."

Sunita looked at her. The left eye sat slightly more open than the right. She had her teeth on the inside of her lower lip, lightly, the way a person bites down to keep from speaking until the speaking has been thought through.

"Your mother's account is open," Sunita said to Iyla. "It should have been closed in October. I deferred the closing because the closing would have cost more than leaving it. The flat is let; the new tenants don't use the gait recognition; I've been telling myself this is accounting." She paused. "It is accounting. It is also other things. I want to be honest about that with you."

Iyla had not breathed since the words *your mother's account*.

"What does open mean," she said.

"It means the door still has her."

Sunita said: “When she walked through, it felt her. Where her weight went. How her hip moved after the stroke. The slowness in March of last year. It had her in stages. The model is — it isn’t a photograph. It is a record of how she moved over time. It is timestamped.”

“A record.”

“With dates. Engineering keeps the annotated history because they use it to debug. I have access because I’ve reviewed her account quarterly since she moved in. I have, in front of me, on a tablet, the entire history of how your mother walked between June 2017 and August of last year.”

She did not put the tablet on the table. She had it in her bag.

Iyla said: “Show me.”

Sunita said: “I will. But I want you to know what asking means. Once you’ve seen this, I cannot un-show it. And the thing the locksmith is here to do — I assume — would not be possible without it.”

Adaeze, who had been listening with her hands flat on her thighs, said: “I have not been able to pick the door. I was hired three weeks ago. I am worse at it now than I was on the first day. The door is getting better at refusing me. I think this is the thing your mother meant. That it would be there when she was gone. The way it knew her. I don’t think she meant it as an instruction. But it can be used as one.”

Iyla looked at the table, not at either of them. The table had a small ring where someone had set down a wet cup. She put her thumb on the ring.

“I want to walk through that door,” she said, “as my mother.”

Sunita said: “The door reads you against a baseline. The baseline is hers. The moment it admits you, it will fold the entry into the baseline. The version it is holding now will not be the version it has after.” She had not yet said the part she had to say. “The model has a high learning rate. It has to. Tenants in this building are old; their gait drifts; if the door clung to a six-month-old version of them it

would lock them out by spring. One entry is enough to move the baseline measurably. Two and the prior version is gone."

"How long."

"Minutes. Possibly less. Possibly the entry itself."

Iyla said: "Then we should be quick."

Adaeze said: "We should not be quick. We should be slow. If you walk through too fast it won't admit you. If you walk through too slow it will read the slowness as different from her slowness. We have to teach you her walk. From the records." She looked at Sunita. "The records you have."

Sunita took out the tablet.

They worked in the empty service corridor on the second floor, where there was no gait-reader and where the cleaners had been and gone. Sunita had the tablet propped against the wall. The screen showed a sequence of small grey diagrams — stick-figures, almost, but with weight visualised as a colour wash that moved from heel to toe. Heel was a bruised oxblood; midfoot was amber; toe was a thin grey that left a trail the next frame had to overwrite.

"This is March 2018," Sunita said. "She would have been fifty-six. The walk is fast. She used to take this corridor, actually, to cut through to the bin store. You can see where she shifts her weight when she turns the corner. It's not symmetrical. The right hip leads."

Iyla watched her mother walk in March 2018 in oxblood and amber. The walk was the walk of a woman who was annoyed about something and not letting it slow her down.

"And this," Sunita said, "is October 2024. After the stroke."

The colour wash on the diagram was different. The oxblood lingered. The amber arrived late. There was a pause at midfoot that had not been there before. The right hip still led; it led less.

"She walked like this for the last year," Sunita said.

Iyla said: "I have not seen my mother walk in nine months."

"I know."

"I'm not sure I remember how she walked. I think I do. I think I might be remembering wrong."

Adaeze said: "You don't have to remember. You have to do it. There's a difference."

Iyla looked at her.

"What I mean," Adaeze said, "is that you don't have to recognise it. Your body has to recognise it. You grew up around her body. You walked behind her on stairs. You walked beside her on streets. There is a thing your body has of how she moved that doesn't go through your head. We're going to find that thing."

Iyla said: "Have you done this before."

"No."

"Then how do you know it will work."

Adaeze said: "I don't. I know the door has spent eight years reading her. I know that bodies that grew up next to her body have something of how she walked. The door is reading for the thing your body has. If your body has it strongly enough and you don't try too hard to remember, the door will accept it. I think there is a chance."

Iyla nodded once. Then she said:

"What if it does work."

Sunita, who had been waiting for this question for the whole twenty minutes since they sat down, said: "It will work. Then the door learns you, performing her. It updates. After a few days it isn't her any more. It's you, slightly. Then it's you.

The version of her it has now will not be retrievable. The walking through is the overwriting."

Iyla said: "You're telling me this on purpose."

"Yes."

"Because you want me to choose."

"I want you to know."

Iyla put her hands flat on her knees. The gesture was her mother's. None of them said so.

She said: "Show me October."

For an hour they worked. Adaeze had Iyla walk the corridor in stockinged feet — *the heels are wrong, the heels are not what the door learned* — and corrected her at the heel, at the hip, at the small pause her mother had developed at midfoot in the last year. Sunita watched the tablet and called timings. *Half a second slower. The pause is longer. The hip — yes. Like that.*

Iyla cried twice, briefly, and did not stop walking.

The corridor had a lino floor that had once been pale green and was now the colour of sour milk. Adaeze walked the length of it with Iyla, beside and slightly behind, calling out the corrections; on the third length she noticed her own right foot was striking off the heel in the rhythm she had been beating into Iyla — half a second's hold at midfoot, then the toe — and she did not know when she had started. She let it pass. Bodies did this.

By the end of the hour Iyla could walk thirty feet of corridor and have it look, on the tablet's silhouette match, like her mother in October 2024 to within a margin Sunita read off as *acceptable*.

Adaeze said: “We do it once. The second time the door will already have begun to update. The second walk won’t be her. The third walk will be you. After that we don’t know.”

Iyla said: “Is there anything in the flat I should — should I bring something out. Should I —”

Sunita said: “There is nothing in the flat. The flat has been emptied. The thing your mother left in the door is in the door. Don’t go looking for something else.”

Iyla nodded. She looked tired. She looked, briefly, like Marguerite. Adaeze noticed. Sunita noticed. Neither said.

They went up to the fourth floor. The corridor outside 4.2 was quiet; it was past ten and the new tenants — both at work — would not be back until evening. The door had a brass handle and a small dark sensor strip below it. Above the handle was the brass plate the building had not replaced when it converted from the old school, with the original room number scratched out and *4.2* engraved over it. The strike was electric; Adaeze had been picking the latch for three weeks. The chime, when admission was granted, lived in a small speaker above the lintel. The door itself was hung on a sprung hinge that closed it slow and even on a count of fifteen.

Sunita stood ten feet back, holding the tablet with the alert page open. She did not look at the screen. She looked at Iyla.

Adaeze said: “When you’re ready. Don’t think about it. Walk to the door. Slow at the heel. The pause at midfoot. The right hip leads. Don’t look at the sensor. Look at the brass plate. She always looked at the brass plate; we don’t know why.”

Iyla said: “Did she.”

Sunita said: “Every time. I watched from the courtyard.”

Iyla’s mouth did something that was not quite a smile. Then she walked.

A learning door, approached by a body it has been waiting for, registers the gait at six metres, at four, at two; each registration narrows a curve; the curve closes or it does not, and the door decides in the last fraction of a second before the foot lands. The chime, if it sounds, is the sound of tolerance achieved. There is a corresponding subroutine, undocumented in the public manuals but visible in the engineering ones Sunita had read, in which the door — having tightened its curve to within tolerance for a known body — folds the new entry back into the baseline. This is the learning. This is what the door is for.

Iyla walked.

At six metres her shoulders dropped. Adaeze had not coached the shoulders. She did not breathe. At four metres the right hip led; the heel struck slightly off; the hip, leading, recovered. At two metres the pause at midfoot arrived — the half-second, the woman's body keeping its arrangement with itself. At the threshold Iyla looked up and to the left, at the brass plate, not at the sensor.

The chime sounded.

The chime was at pitch.

The door opened.

Iyla stood at the threshold. She did not go in. The door, having opened, waited on its sprung hinge.

Behind her, in the corridor, Sunita's tablet vibrated once.

She looked down.

The screen said:

ALLEYNE, M. — flat 4.2 — model updated. New entry recorded 10:47:14. Confidence: 0.94. Drift from baseline: within tolerance.

Below that, in smaller text:

Baseline updated.

Sunita put her hand to her mouth. A sound came out of her — a vowel without a consonant — and she did not recognise it as her own.

Adaeze, who had been watching Iyla's back, turned at the sound. She saw Sunita's face. She knew before she read the screen.

She said, quietly: "It updated."

Sunita said: "Yes."

"How long do we have."

"It's done. The baseline updated when she crossed."

Iyla, at the threshold, had not moved. She was looking into the empty flat — the floor where her mother's rug had been, the wall where the bookcase had stood, the patch of paint slightly lighter than the rest where a photograph had hung for a decade — and what she was feeling was that the door had let her in as her mother and that this was the first time in eight months she had felt her mother in any room, and the room had nothing in it.

She said, without turning: "Thank you."

She did not know whom she was thanking.

Adaeze said: "Iyla. Come back."

"In a minute."

"Now. Please."

Iyla turned. She saw Adaeze's face and Sunita's face. She saw Sunita's hand at Sunita's mouth.

She said: "What."

Sunita lowered the hand. "The door has updated its baseline. The version of your mother's walk that it had — the October version — has been merged with yours. The next walk through this door, by anyone, is read against the merged baseline. By tomorrow the model will be more you than her. By next week it will be you."

Iyla said: "I —"

There was nothing on the end of *I*.

Adaeze said: “I took your money and I was wrong about what the job was.”

She did not say the rest. She had said the thing about the money because the money was the thing she could account for. She let the silence be a silence.

Iyla did not look at her. She was looking at her hands. She had stopped, eight months ago, saying sentences that began *I thought*, because she had noticed they were always wrong and the noticing had become unbearable; and so she did not say *I thought there would be a delay*, and she did not say *I thought I would have time inside the room with her still in the door behind me*, and the sentences sat in her chest where she had been keeping them, and were not said.

She said: “Can you — is there a backup.”

Sunita said: “There is no backup. The baseline is the file. Engineering doesn’t keep prior versions past forty-eight hours and the last forty-eight hours don’t go back far enough.”

“The annotated history. You have the annotated history. The diagrams.”

“I have the diagrams. They aren’t the model. They’re a record of how the model was trained. The door uses the baseline. The baseline has been updated.”

“So I —”

“Yes.”

The door, on its slow hinge, was closing on its count. Iyla watched it close. She did not put her hand against it. She let it close.

When it had closed Adaeze said, because someone had to say something: “She would have wanted you to be let in.”

Iyla said, without unkindness: “Don’t.”

Adaeze did not.

They went down in the lift in silence. In the lobby Sunita stopped. “I have to go back to the office. I have to log this. If I don’t log it, it will be flagged as an anomaly tonight and there will be a question I can’t answer in the morning.”

Iyla said: “Log what.”

“That a non-tenant entry was recorded against your mother’s baseline. I have to attribute it. I am going to attribute it to a hardware test. It will not be your name.”

“Why are you doing that.”

“Because if I don’t, you’ll have a record.”

“And what will you have.”

Sunita looked at her.

“I will have falsified an engineering log. It is the first time. I notice that I am not particularly upset about it. That is a thing I will think about later.”

She turned to go. Then she stopped, and she did not turn back, but she said over her shoulder: “Your mother had Earl Grey every morning for eight years. She sat with her shoulders down. On Fridays she had a different book. I never spoke to her. I want you to know I never spoke to her. The reading was entirely one-sided. I don’t know if that is a comfort or its opposite. I wanted to say it out loud once.”

Iyla said: “It is a comfort. I think.”

Sunita walked across the lobby. Her gait, Adaeze noticed, was slightly off the heel and had a half-second pause at midfoot that had not been there an hour ago.

Adaeze walked Iyla out to the courtyard. Iyla had a train to catch back to Manchester. They did not speak about the next time. Adaeze, who was usually good at the small conversation that closed a job, found nothing in her mouth that would have been honest, and so said only: “I’ll send my invoice tomorrow.”

Iyla said: “Send it for the three weeks. Not for today.”

“That isn’t right. Today is when —”

“Send it for the three weeks. I’ll pay it.”

She walked away across the courtyard, and her walk was not her mother's, and it was also not the walk she had arrived with, and Adaeze stood under the brick arch at the courtyard's south end and watched her go and did not know which of these to grieve.

Her own foot, on the cobble, hesitated at midfoot before the toe left.

In the accounts office, Sunita sat at her desk. The tablet was face down. She did not turn it over. She opened the engineering log on her computer and wrote a sentence she had written before, for other reasons — *Hardware diagnostic test, sensor strip 4.2, no tenant present* — and submitted it. The system accepted it.

She closed the engineering log.

She opened the accounts page for ALLEYNE, M. The line that had said *model retained pending overwrite* had updated itself. It now said *baseline current; account active.*

Active.

The word sat there. The system had just told her, in its flat administrative voice, that the account had never been more current than it was now. The model had been refreshed. The tenant — by the only definition the system used — was here.

She wrote a new note in the comments field. *Defer review. Q3.* She saved it.

Then she sat with her hands flat on the desk and did not move for a long time. Outside, in the lobby, the inner doors chimed at pitch as a tenant came home from work and was admitted by a baseline that had been updated that morning, and that admitted him as itself.

In a flat in Yaba, Adaeze was on a video call with her sister Ifeoma in London, who was a junior associate at a firm Adaeze had once been asked to consult for, and who had been the one to send her the notice about the exclusivity contracts when they were first drafted. Ifeoma was eating toast. Adaeze was not eating. The window behind Adaeze had the late Lagos light in it, the light that turned the flat the colour of weak tea for fifteen minutes before it went out.

Ifeoma said: *You're quiet.*

Adaeze said: *I had a job today.*

The Manchester one.

Yes.

Did you get the door.

Adaeze said: *I didn't get it. The daughter got it.*

Ifeoma waited. She kept eating toast.

Adaeze said: *I taught her to walk like the mother. The door let her in. The door updated. The mother is — the mother isn't there any more. We did that.*

Ifeoma said: *Adaeze.*

Adaeze said: *I'm going to take one of the contracts.*

She had not known she was going to say it until she said it. She heard herself say it and she did not take it back. Ifeoma stopped eating.

Which one.

I don't know. The one that pays. The retainer one. The one where I don't pick.

Ifeoma said: *That's not what you do.*

Adaeze said: *I know.*

The light went out behind her in the way the Lagos light went out, all at once, and the flat became the colour of the lamp on the desk, which was a yellow that had nothing in it of evening. She said good night to Ifeoma and ended the call and sat on the edge of the bed with her foot on the floor and felt the small hesitation at

midfoot when she stood up to go to the kitchen, and she felt it and she let it be felt, and she did not yet sign anything, and she did not yet not sign anything.

System: unslop.
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